



Checkmate in Canada

India has its **task cut out** against some serious competition in its FIDE Candidates showdown.

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The flavour may be more Indian at the Candidates in Toronto, but two Americans look the strongest contenders along with a Russian who has won the tournament's last two editions.

R. Praggnanandhaa, D. Gukesh and Vidit Gujrathi have ensured India has a strong presence — not to mention Koneru Humpy and R. Vaishali in the women's event. But they are up against very strong opposition.

Americans Fabiano Caruana and Hikaru Nakamura should be most people's favourites. And Russia's Ian Nepomniachtchi cannot be ignored.

In order to win the tournament and thus

Firm favourite: Caruana is a former winner of the Candidates. He had won it in 2018 and took on Carlsen for the World championship later that year. LENNART OOTES

earn the right to challenge Ding Liren for the World Chess Championship, the Indians have to find ways to race ahead of their formidable opponents.

Caruana and Nakamura have been among the world's best players for a long time. Caruana is ranked second in the world behind five-time World champion Magnus Carlsen, who relinquished the title, paving the way for last year's World title match between Ding and Nepomniachtchi.

Caruana is the player to beat in Toronto. With 2804 Elo points, he is just 26 behind Carlsen, the world's strongest player of all time. Caruana's peak rating was 2844 and, apart from Carlsen (2882), only one other player has ever been rated higher — Garry Kasparov (2851).

Caruana is also a former winner of the